

TOP 10 WEB LOG ANALYSERS



Today's Web hosting data centres deploy multiple servers, running many operating systems. With the growing number of online businesses, it's important to know how many customers reach your websites. Beyond just the number of hits, it is imperative to understand customer behaviour and market trends, which needs Web analytics. This article looks at the top 10 analysis tools for website access, categorised by popularity, functionality and ease of use. They are, essentially, must have gadgets in every network administrator's toolbox.

Websites directly catering to a business are always complex for the business owner, as well as the technology support team. Owners want to know things like how many hits are generated over a period of time, and also which product pages are being accessed more frequently than others. This information is essential for them to correlate it directly or indirectly with the sales and profit figures. The owner would also be interested in customer trends. For example, they may want to find out if Web users are trying to access a particular set of products just because those products are on discount.

From the technology support standpoint, administrators want to ensure the reliability and stability of their websites.

If the Web hits are increasing, they would want to know what impact this can have on CPUs and memory usage, as well as on the network throughput. Similarly, it would be important for them to know if and when the servers' hardware needs upgrades, or when to add more Web servers into the pool. Another requirement could be to troubleshoot website-related problems by looking at the HTTP error field (for instance, a 404 means that links on the website point to non-existent pages, causing a bad user experience).

Web servers create detailed and verbose Web logs in the form of text files. All fields are important for analytics; however, Table 1 lists fields that are crucial for analysing website usage and trends.